myself to perform better and raise the bar of action with every film. I want to entertain everyone."

Tiger has not only established himself with daredevil stunts and the image of an action star, but also become the epitome of stylish dance, owning signature moves. The handsome hunk is all about sleek action, martial arts, and suave dance steps. Tiger shares that he started dancing "just five years prior to my debut film but for me, it's very important. For me, it's not only about fitness but also about expressing myself through movement. It is also a way to relax for me."

The busy actor is also considered someone reliable to work with by those in the trade, who continue to work with him in repeat projects. "Tiger appeals to kids, their mothers, their fathers and even grandparents! I think there aren't many actors in the film industry whose appeal is universal and ageless," says producer Jackky Bhagnani. Tiger had signed a three-film deal with Jackky Bhagnani's production house, and after *Ganapath*, the next two are the upcoming *Bade Miyan Chote Miyan* and *Hero No. 1*.

The action star is bracing for a slew of releases in 2024-25, including *Rambo*, produced by Siddharth Anand. He also recently wrapped up some spectacular action in Hyderabad for Rohit Shetty's *Singham Again* and audiences can't wait to see it. ■

Aarti Kapur Singh

OTT

The Joy of BEING QUEER

JAYDEEP SARKAR'S ***RAINBOW RISHTA*** ON AMAZON PRIME LOOKS AT QUEER RELATIONSHIPS IN A REFRESHING NEW WAY

A "romantic documentary series" is not a description you see every day, but that's how Amazon Prime Video is presenting *Rainbow Rishta* on its homepage. The six-episode series tracks six stories of LGBTQIA+ individuals trying to find love or have their relationships socially validated, in Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru, Guwahati and Imphal.

Unlike cinematic representation of queer people that focuses on the social discrimination and violence they face, *Rainbow Rishta* is consistently and deliberately heartwarming. "Growing up queer, we saw ourselves as either victims, villains, or clowns for comic relief," says Jaydeep Sarkar, the series director and executive producer. "Naturally, we wouldn't get the courage to come out. What I wanted to do here is show queer joy. When so many of us are together, there's so much laughter and affection. Why don't we see that on screen?"

A case in point is the story of Mumbai couple Daniella and Joel preparing to get married. The show focuses on the bittersweet challenges they face in the run-up to their wedding, such as Daniella's search for the right dress. Her horrifying history of being a transwoman who was sold to *hijras* as a child is addressed but not dwelled on in depth.

Other stories include young lesbian couple Aneez and Sanam's hunt for an apartment where they'll be accepted; the search for love of *Made in Heaven* actor Trinetra Haldar, activist Sadam, and human rights lawyer Ayushmaan, whose alter ego is the drag queen Lush Monsoon; and long-term couple Soham and Suresh trying to live a life of dignity and transparency.

Rather than focusing only on the discrimination queer people face, *Rainbow Rishta* is consistently and deliberately heartwarming







Interestingly, Sarkar and his team did not turn the six stories into individual episodes but had each story play off one another. "I did not want to turn this into an anthology series of queer stories," explains Sarkar. "I wanted each story to comment on one another. So, Aneez and Sanam have love but not home. Trinetra has home but not love."

Among the series' winning aspects is the forthrightness with which the subjects, their families, and their partners speak on camera and allow the filmmakers to capture intimate moments. "Queer people are always bullied and encouraged to hide themselves and their stories," says Sarkar. "We're told that if we're in the room, we'd better stand in the corner and not ask for more. This was an opportunity to negate such thinking."

Kolkata-born Sarkar, 44, had assisted Anurag Kashyap and wrote films for Sudhir Mishra in the 2000s before switching to advertising over the past decade because of a "lack of opportunity to tell our stories". With *Rainbow Rishta*, that has changed. "Queer people previously would be seen from the lens of how promiscuous we are or how much sex we are having," says Sarkar. "This series has shaken up that view, has humanised us. If you have gas from chaat-samosa, we also have gas from chaat-samosa. We're no different." ■

Devarsi Ghosh